To: USTA NorCal Section Sportsmanship Committee

From: [redacted]

Subject: Unfairly kicked out of the Gold Cup Series USTA tournament August 25-26
Grievance against Roger Okmoto –USTA Gold Cup tournament Mt. View Tournament Director – USTA # 922531702

Date: August 22, 2018

To the Committee Chair

I have played USTA tournaments for over 20 years and I have had my share of issue but I have payed dearly for somethings which I didn't deserved but I have handled myself as professionally as possible.

I have always carried myself in a professional manner and treat all players, tournament Director and referee with the utmost respect. I have been treated unfairly and had to just humble myself and accept the unfair treatment I have received. I have been unseeded in tournament when I should have and I have voiced my disagreement and told to just be quiet and play! I have been treated unfairly in matches where players curse at me and use profanity and I deal with it and report it and nothing is ever done. Yet if I do anything that seems like I broken any USTA rule I am suspended, awards taken away from and the list goes on. I was once told in a grievance hearing that as long as I have played tennis I should know all the rules no excuse accepted. I have been treated harshly even when I am totally innocent of any wrong doing. I continue to lift my head and accept the crap I have thrown at me and still remain professional and show good sportsmanship always.

My grievance is against Roger Okamoto the tournament Director - Mt. View Gold Cup tournament. Grounds for my grievance is as follows:

My partner entered the Mt. View tournament and selected me as her partner on August 15, 2018. I finally signed up on Saturday August 18, 2018. Entries closed at 11:59 August 18, 2018 at 11 pm. On Monday August 20 I received a noreply email stating that I was not selected into the draw and put on the alternate listing. The number of entries for this tournament were 5 teams including Caren Doyle and myself. My partner and I would have been the #2 seed. In the email it said if you have any questions contact Roger Okamoto the tournament director. I email him right away and even left a voice mail shortly after I received the noreply email notice. Roger didn't respond by email or took the time to return my call.

I wrote on Monday August 20, 2018 to Michelle Wilson and Steve Leube asking for help and didn't get a response so I called Michelle and explain to her what had happen to me. She told me that I should call him or email him and ask for an explanation. I explained to her I had done both but still no reply back. I asked her what can I do if he doesn't give me a valid reason or doesn't respond back to me she if that happens I could contact her again. I wanted but still no reply back from Roger Okamoto so on Tuesday I drove to the USTA office in Alameda to speak with Michelle Wilson in person. Michelle was kind enough to speak with me without an appointment and I explained to her what was happening and she listen but

at the end said the Roger has posted the following: "Right to Refusal" and he can kick me out of the tournament based on this rule. I asked her how can he do that I have never done anything to him, no suspension points, no grievance against me, no complaint of unsportsmanship behavior ever at his tournament a since I played in this tournament from 2003. I have not played every year in fact I only played this tournament 6 times and one was when he wasn't the tournament Director. The only thing that I may have done was give him a bad review because he wouldn't allow me to play two doubles events even when the draw had only two teams. As a doubles player only I do have a right to write my evaluation of not only his tournament but anyone tournament and if I am not allowed to play two doubles events I will write the same negative evaluation. That is my right and I was always professional in my remarks and comments.

Michelle said she had reached out to him and was waiting for a call back and I told I was concern because I had done nothing to him and I really wanted to play this tournament which would keep our hopes alive of winning the Player of the Year Award. She told me she is waiting on his call and he has the "Right of Refusal" but she said he should give me a reason and I left the office very hurt and disappointed.

When I returned home Roger had completed the draw and posted the time and my partner and I was excluded from his tournament. Roger called me and I am sure it was because Michelle Wilson either told him or suggested that he owed me a phone call and explanation. I will request a letter from Michelle Wilson as to when she spoke with him what reason did he give her to kick me out of his tournament to compare to what he told me the reason why he kicked me out of his tournament.

In Rogers Okamoto own words here is the reason he gave me for kicking me out of his tournament:

- He was upset with me for filing a grievance against Jennifer Eldred (AKA Jenifer Buchholz back in 2016). He told me that it showed unsportsmanship conduct because I told her I felt she was a 4.5 player and win or lose I was going to file a grievance against her which is my right. We lost pretty badly to an unknown team and to this day I still feel she is a 4.5 or higher player.
- Roger had nothing else against me other than the fact I filed a grievance against Jennifer and to this day I have no idea how she was able to enter the tournament as Jennifer Eldred when her USTA number is : 2001855945 and her name is listed as Jennifer Buchholz the same name as the 4.5 player in New England who played one match at the Sectional championships and that was in 2015 and since then there is no record of her ever playing any tournaments or leagues USTA events.
- Roger couldn't come up with any other reason for kicking me out and to be honest I begged and pleaded with him to forgive me for anything I did or anything he thought I did to offend him. I explained to him that this tournament was very important to me and my partner in order to give us a chance at winning the Player of the Year award and his comment was this:

  I DON'T CARE ABOUT THAT STUFF IT ISN'T IMPORTANT TO ME AND IN FACT IT DOESN'T MATTER MY ANSWER IS NO GO PLAY OTHER TOURNAMENTS AND I AM DONE TALKING TO YOU!!!

I was very upset and I humbled myself and begged for him to allow me and my partner to play but he pretty much said no and was done talking to me. I told him I would file a grievance against him and if that is me showing unsportsmanship conduct or having a unsportsmanship issue in 2017 (I didn't play his tournament the email from Caren Doyle is attached) like he told my partner over the phone on August 19 which he had no right to share any of my personal information about my past with anyone this could be seen as deformation of character if he speaks about false information which he did about me.

Roger Okamoto has been the tournament Director since 2008 and prior to him it was Howard Chen who ran this tournament and everyone loved it. He allowed all players to be selected there was no "Right of Refusal" There was no rule not allowing two doubles. In 2008 Roger Okamoto took over and for his first tournament "Right of Refusal" wasn't on the tournament page and playing two doubles was allowed. I played this his first tournament and I truly enjoyed playing this South Bay event. I played only 5 of his tournament after that and even when the draws were small he wouldn't bend the rules and allow a player to play two double events. I would still ask due to the fact the entries were small but he wouldn't bend his rules and I had to accept this and I did. I didn't like it being a doubles player only and with tournament entries becoming smaller and smaller I just thought that for the good of the game and make it a players tournament he would change but he didn't!

Here is my issue and I will let the Sportsmanship Committee do their own investigation in regards to this grievance. I would like this committee to contact the following players to get additional facts and their statements on this issue .

- Roger Okamoto held a grudge against me for two years and without any notification kicked me out of his tournament that will cost me and my partner chance of winning Player of the Year
- My partner Caren Doyle is in the running for women's 4.0 singles withdrew and losing her chance of winning women's 4.0 singles Player of the Year award!
- Roger Okamoto showed unprofessionalism in his decision kicking me out of the his tournament, he showed bias, prejudice and perhaps racism against me due to how he treated me compared to others including my doubles partner Caren Doyle. He took the time to call her and inform her he has kicked me out of the tournament but he didn't give me the same consideration or phone call. Michelle Wilson the USTA Tournament Director more than likely made him call me since he would have never done it on his own.
- Holding a grudge against a USTA member/player for two years is premanditated hatred of someone which as a USTA tournament Director can't allow his personal feelings towards a USTA member/Player because he doesn't like them, he doesn't like what they do that would be compared to kicking someone out due to their race, creed, color or even if they didn't like their tennis attire.
- The "Rule of Right to Refusal should be banned if a tournament Director can't be fair with everyone. I have seen players curse, throw raquets, almost fight at Roger's tournament and he

did nothing to them but yet he kicks me out of his tournament because I filed a grievance against a player I felt was playing out of level. It was just my opinion and I am allowed to my opinion or has things changed so much in American we are not allowed our Freedom of Speech right!!

- He can allow doubles standards to other players but he kicks me out because he didn't like the fact I filed a grievance against Jennifer Eldred/AKA Jennifer Buchholz. He is just a tournament Director, USTA member, a USTA tennis player yet he used his power as a Tournament Director and the rule with no procedures or process to enforce simply a statement on a Tournament page:

  "RIGHT OF REFUSAL"

  This leads to bias, racism and prejudice for any reason or no reason without having to justify your reason for applying this to a player you decide you personally don't like. What really hurts is he held on to this for two years and just wanted to use this against me now!! If he had a problem with me or my actions then use the Sportsmanship Committee and file a grievance against me. I would have accepted that and I would have gone to the hearing and defended myself against his grievance but he didn't file anything against me he just waited until I signed up. I guess if I would have signed up last year he would have kicked me out! If I knew his intention then when I made my tournament schedule then I would have crossed this tournament off as one not to play. This rule has to be changed or deleted unless the USTA NorCal can write a procedure and process to make this a fair rule for all players not for a Tournament Director how held a grudge for over two year against a player unfairly!!!

- I don't understand his actions, I pay to play tournament and no Tournament Director is bigger than **the BYLAWS OF THE USTA NORCAL OR USTA NATIONAL OFFICE. The BYLAWS STATE CLEARLY THIS TYPE OF BEHAVIOR WILL NOT BE ACCEPTABLE BY ANYONE NO MATTER THE POSITION, TITLE, SECTION LOCATION, TOURNAMENTS OR LEAGUE PLAY EVER!!!!**
- Bias, racism, prejudice and holding a grudge against me for filing a grievance against a player I played against in his tournament two years ago by the name of Jennifer Eldred (AKA Jennifer Buchholz) I filed a grievance and there was a big case of mistaken identity and still I don't know all the details but I lost the grievance and I moved on. I still believe she is a 4.5 player but that is just my opinion since I am the one who played against her and her Dad. I apologized to the Sportsmanship committee but the chances of two ladies with the same first and last name living in on the East Coast and West Coast is just odd.
- Jennifer Eldred has no record at all when you do a search on USTA website when she played in the Mt. View tournament where Roger show her on the draw sheet with her father the team of Stephen Buchholz/Jennifer Eldred in 2016.

Please contact the following during your investigation of my grievance:

- Caren Doyle USTA number: 10684345
- Michelle Wilson
- My Lam USTA number: [redacted] She reported all the information to Roger Okamoto in regards to Jennifer Eldred (AKA Jennifer Buchholz) then complained to Roger Okamoto and said he didn't do anything so she told me and my partner about she thought that this player was a 4.5 and had proof and shared it with Roger Okamoto she told me he never responded to her email and did nothing about it. I believe her which perhaps was a mistake but all the information she shared with me really pointed to the fact the Jennifer Buchholz rated 4.5 in New England MA section was the same player not calling herself Jennifer Eldred/AKA Jennifer Buchholz.
- Azir Yazdi USTA number: 11620978 My Lam doubles partner.

The Goal of the USTA NorCal and USTA National Office is to GROW the game, promote play and encourage players to continue to play and enjoy tennis. It is clear Roger Okamoto has lost sight of this simple GOAL!! Tournaments play has been on the decrease for a couple of years and Tournaments aren't doing much to encourage play for players. Not allowing two doubles, the 10 point tie-breaker in lieu of a third set. Entry fee's rising but actual play decreasing, so many tournaments can't fill a complete draw yet I have remained loyal to USTA tournaments as well as league play. All I want is to be able to play the game I enjoy and do my best to get better and better that is all I desire. I have played more tournament matches than any player in the history of the USTA and they did a cutoff as of 1998 yet I began playing before that and still remain the only player to play as many tournaments as I have. That should speak for itself but I am sure it has no bearing on this grievance and it shouldn't I agree I hope this committee will just be open to just looking at things standing in my shoes and just be fair in your decision of this grievance.

In my conclusion to the Sportsmanship Committee I know the tournament will be over by the time you get to this grievance. I will have lost out on my chance to win Player of the Year but I truly want my grievance heard so that this will never happen to another player. I do feel this "Right of Refusal" can be used in a negative fashion which is not how the USTA should be using any rule that is bias, prejudice or could be considered racist in how it would be used against certain players.

Regards

[redacted]

Joelle

- Caren Doyle <carendoyle@sbcglobal.net>
-
- Aug 20 at 3:37 PM

To

- Joelle Miller

Hide

Message body

The tournament director contacted you about this, right? He called me last night after I left Silverado to explain that he was going to block our entry (because of a sportsmanship issue from last year). I hoped he would talk to you and reconsider but obviously he didn't.

I dropped out of the singles too. I don't need the drama - and I don't really want to give this tournament any of my $$ either. I can play a couple of tournaments in September so we can make up the points. It's just stupid but politics and petty dictators are everywhere. It should just be about the tennis...

Caren

----- Forwarded Message -----

From: "noreply@usta-active.com" <noreply@usta-active.com>
To: carendoyle@sbcglobal.net
Sent: Monday, August 20, 2018 2:56 PM
Subject: Tournament Entry

Caren,

We regret to inform you that you were not selected into the NTRP Mixed 4.0 Doubles of the South Bay NTRP - A USTA NORCAL NTRP GOLD CUP SERIES TOURNAMENT (500029418) in Mountain View, CA. However, your name has been submitted as an

alternate. The tournament director will contact you should they need you for an opening. Your credit card has not been charged. If you do not wish to remain on the alternates list please contact the tournament director.

Tournament questions should be directed to Roger Okamoto at: Phone Number: 650 935-4564
Email Address: southbayntrp@gmail.com

Regards,
The TennisLink Team